The Paper Menagerie

By Ken Liu

JACK: **(Pg 178-192)** One of my earliest memories starts with me sobbing. I refused to be soothed no matter what Mom and Dad tried. Dad gave up, but Mom took me into the kitchen and sat me down at the breakfast table.

*"**Kan, kan**,"* she said, as she pulled a sheet of wrapping paper from on top of the fridge. She set the paper down and began to fold it. I stopped crying and watched her, curious. She turned the paper over and folded it again. She pleated, packed, tucked, rolled, and twisted until the paper disappeared between her cupped hands. She lifted the folded paper to her mouth and blew into it, like a balloon, then put her hands down on the table and let go.

MOM: ***Kan . . .Laohu***

JACK: A little paper tiger stood on the table. Its tail twitched -- *"**Rawrr-sa**."* I laughed and stroked its

4NG Fanatics

back with an index finger. *"**Zhe jiao zhezhi**,"* Mom said. ***This is called origami.*** At my request, Mom also made a goat, a deer and a water buffalo out of wrapping paper. – A paper menagerie. . . I didn't know this at the time, but Mom's kind was special. She breathed into them so that they moved with her life. This was her magic.

INTRODUCTION

**According to a 2023 Pew Research Study, 1 in 5 Asian American adults say they have hidden a part of their heritage – cultural customs, food, clothing or religious practices from non-Asians at some point in their lives. Why? Fear of ridicule and a desire to fit in are the most common reasons. Being from a mixed culture sounds glamorous; but for many it is a challenge.*

In this selection, Jack grows up with one heart and two cultural identities. From a young age, he struggles to find common ground with his mother, a mail-order bride from Hong Kong who speaks little English and the American values which he obviously prefers. Can he find it in his heart to love his mother despite their differences?

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JACK: [When I was ten], one of the neighborhood boys, came over with his Star Wars action figures. Obi-Wan Kenobi's lightsaber lit up; he could

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swing his arms and say, "Use the Force!" *(to Mark)* Can he do anything else? *(to audience)* Mark was annoyed by my question.

MARK: Show me your toys!

JACK: I didn't have any toys except my paper menagerie. I brought ***Laohu*** out from my bedroom and sat him down on the coffee table.

MARK: *(examining the tiger, scoffing)* Doesn't look like a tiger at all. Your Mom makes toys for you from trash?

JACK: I had never thought of ***Laohu*** as *trash.* But looking at him now, he was really just a piece of paper. Mark pushed Obi-Wan' s head again. The lightsaber flashed; he moved his arms up and down. "Use the Force!" ***Laohu*** turned and pounced, knocking Obi-Wan off the table. *"**Rawwww!**"* [But when] it hit the floor and broke, Mark punched me, hard. Gabbed ***Laohu***, crumpled him in his hand, tore him in half and threw them at me.

MARK: *(throwing with anger)* Here's your stupid cheap Chinese garbage.

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JACK: After Mark left, I spent a long time trying to tape together the pieces, smooth out the paper, and follow the creases to refold ***Laohu***. *(beat)* At dinner I asked Dad, "Do I have a chink face?"

MOM: *(looking confused)*"***Sha jiao chink***?"

JACK: *(to himself) I look nothing like her, nothing! (to Mom)* English! Speak English!

MOM: *(trying)* What happen?

JACK: *(ignoring her)* I pushed the chopsticks and the bowl before me away. "We should eat American food."

DAD: A lot of families cook Chinese sometimes.

JACK: We are **not** other families. *(to himself) Other families don't have Moms who don't belong.*

MOM: ***Bu haochi?***

JACK: *(raising his voice)* English . . . Speak English! *(to audience)* Mom reached out to touch my forehead, feeling for my temperature.

MOM: ***Fashao la?***

JACK: *(brushing her hand away)* I'm fine. Speak English! *(to audience)* She tried to speak, stopped; tried and stopped again.

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MOM: "If I say ***'love***,' I feel here." *(points to her lips)* "If I say '***ai***,' I feel here." *(puts her hand over her heart)*

JACK: *(shaking his head)* You are in America . . . And I want some real toys! *(to audience)* Dad bought me a full set of Star Wars action figures, [and] I packed the paper menagerie in a shoebox and shoved it into the corner of the attic.

"You shouldn't treat your mother that way," Dad said. But he couldn't look me in the eyes as he said it. Deep in his heart, he must have realized that it was a mistake to have tried to take a Chinese peasant girl and expect her to fit in the suburbs of Connecticut.

If Mom spoke to me in Chinese, I refused to answer her. After a while, she tried to use more English. But her accent and broken sentences embarrassed me. Eventually, she stopped speaking altogether if I was around. Every once in a while, I would see her at the kitchen table studying a sheet of wrapping paper. Later a new paper animal would appear on my nightstand. I

4NG Fanatics

squeezed them until the air went out and stuffed them away in the box in the attic.

Mom finally stopped making the animals when I was in high school. By then her English was much better, but I was already at that age . . . I wasn't interested in what she had to say whatever language she used. It was hard for me to believe that she gave birth to me. We had nothing in common.

[And we still didn't six years later when] Dad and I stood, one on each side of Mom, lying on the hospital bed. She was not yet forty, but she looked much older. For years she had refused to go to the doctor. By the time an ambulance finally carried her in, the cancer had spread far beyond the limits of surgery.

My mind was not in the room. It was the middle of campus recruiting season, and I was focused on resumes, transcripts, and interviews. I understood that it was terrible to think about this while your mother lay dying, but that didn't

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change how I felt. I reached out to touch her hand because that was what I was supposed to do.

MOM: Jack, if I . . . don't make it, don't be sad. Focus on your life. Just keep that box you have in the attic with you, and once in a while take it out and think about me. I'll be with you always.

JACK: *(puzzled at first, then remembers; to himself)* The paper menagerie hidden in the darkness of the attic for so long . . . *(to Mom)* Just rest, Mom.

MOM: Just open it once in a while. Just open – *(coughing spell)* ***Haizi, mama ai ni***

JACK: An image from years ago flashed into my memory: Mom saying ***ai*** and then putting her hand over her heart. *(to Mom)* It's okay, Mom. *(stroking her arm awkwardly)* Stop talking. *(to audience)* Dad came back, and I said that I needed to get to the airport early because I didn't want to miss my flight. *(long beat)* She died when my plane was somewhere over Nevada.

After [that], the paper animals did not move. Perhaps I had only imagined that [they] were

4NG Fanatics

once alive. The memory of children could not be trusted. *(beat)*

It was two years after Mom's death. I was home, flipping through the TV channels, [when I heard] a rustle. I looked up and saw a ball of wrapping paper and torn tape on the floor. I walked over to pick it up. The ball of paper shifted, unfurled itself, and I saw that it was ***Laohu***, who I hadn't thought about in a very long time. *"**Raw-sa**."* Mom must have put him back together after I had given up. I reached out a finger. **Laohu**'s tail twitched, and he pounced playfully. I laughed, stroking his back. "How've you been, old buddy?" ***Laohu*** stopped playing and proceeded to unfold himself. [There] in my [hand] was a square of creased wrapping paper, the plain side up. It was filled with dense Chinese characters in Mom's handwriting. The language that I had tried to forget for years came back, and I felt the words sinking through my skin until they squeezed tight around my heart.

MOM'S VOICE *(as JACK reads silently)***:**

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Son, We haven't talked in a long time. You are so angry when I try to touch you that I'm afraid. And I think maybe this pain I feel all the time now is something serious.

But if I write to you with all my heart, I'll leave a little of myself behind on this paper, in these words. Then the creatures I made for you will again leap and run and pounce, and maybe you'll get to see these words.

[When] you were born! I was so happy. When you said your first words to me, in Chinese I cried for hours. When I made the first **zhezhi** *animals for you, and you laughed, I felt there were no worries in the world.*

Son, I know that you do not like your Chinese eyes, which are my eyes. I know that you do not like your Chinese hair, which is my hair. But can you understand how much joy your very existence brought to me? *Can you understand how it felt when you stopped talking to me and wouldn't let me talk to you in Chinese? I felt I was losing everything all over again. You know what the Chinese think is the saddest feeling in the world? For a child to finally grow the desire to take care of his parents, only to realize that they [are] gone.*

Why won't you talk to me, son?

JACK: *(beat)* [Her] pain makes it hard to bear. *(beat)* Following the creases, I refolded the paper back into ***Laohu***. I cradled him in the crook of my arm, and as he purred, I traced out the character for ***ai*** on the paper, intertwining my pen strokes with her words.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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4NG fanatics

Translations

1. ***"kan" – translation -- "look or watch"***
2. ***"laohu" – translation – "tiger"***
3. ***"Sha jiao chink?" – translation -- "What is a chink?"***
4. ***"Bu haochi" – translation -- "not tasty or not good tasting"***
5. ***"Fashao la" – translation -- "fever"***
6. ***"ai" – translation – "love"***
7. ***"Haizi, mama ai ni" – translation – "Son, I love you"***

**** Introduction Source Information***
https://www.pewresearch.org/short-reads/2023/09/11/among-asian-americans-us-born-children-of-immigrants-are-most-likely-to-have-hidden-part-of-their-heritage/

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